



Story 2 — *Echoes Over Blackpine Valley*

Helicopter Story

The rotors of the H-92 Falcon cut through the morning fog as Captain Mara Ellison guided the aircraft over Blackpine Valley. The helicopter vibrated with a steady rhythm — a heartbeat of machinery and purpose.

Below her, the valley stretched like a green ocean, waves of pine trees rolling toward distant mountains. Mara had flown rescue missions for eight years, but today's call felt different. A hiker had gone missing after a sudden landslide, and the weather was turning fast.

"Visibility dropping," her co-pilot Jonah warned.

"I see it," Mara replied, adjusting the throttle. The Falcon dipped lower, skimming the treetops.

A flash of orange caught her eye — a torn backpack strap dangling from a broken branch. Mara swung the helicopter around, hovering with precision. Jonah lowered the winch while Mara held the Falcon steady against the rising wind.

Minutes felt like hours. Then Jonah's voice crackled through the headset. "Got him! He's alive!"

Mara exhaled, relief washing over her. She lifted the Falcon higher, climbing above the storm clouds. The rescued hiker lay strapped to the stretcher, exhausted but safe.

As they flew back toward base, Mara looked out at the valley. The world below was wild, unpredictable, and sometimes unforgiving. But up here — in the cockpit, with the hum of the rotors and the weight of responsibility — she felt a clarity she couldn't find anywhere else.

Flying wasn't just her job.

It was her calling.